



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

IN PACIFIC PALISADES, above, there were about 60 burned lots for sale as of Thursday, according to Zillow. In Altadena, there were 32.

Ashes barely cold, the fire sales begin

Developers are buying burned lots — ‘so many to choose from,’ an agent says.

BY ANDREW KHOURI

The first vacant lot in Altadena went up for sale in late January. The listing promised “great opportunity to build” after the Eaton fire destroyed the home previously on the site. A few weeks later came half a dozen more listings. Now the floodgates appear open.

“There is so many to choose from,” said Jeremy Hardy, a real estate agent with Craig Estates & Fine Properties. Two months after fires that tore through Los Angeles County and destroyed or seriously damaged more than 12,000 homes, property owners in Altadena and Pacific Palisades are increasingly selling their burned lots rather than undertake a time-consuming and costly rebuilding process. As of Thursday, there were about 60 burned lots for sale in Pacific Palisades, according to Zillow. In Altadena, there were 32.

Real estate agents said their clients who chose to sell, or are debating it, are doing so for a variety of reasons. Some doubt they have the money to rebuild. Others are elderly and don’t want their last years consumed by construction. A few had rental properties and decided keeping them was not worth the hassle. Many — if not most — of the people interested in buying burned lots have been developers, according to agents. It’s perhaps not surprising. Vacant land is typically bought with cash. Construction [See Land sales, A10]



JULIANA YAMADA Los Angeles Times

GIVEN that land is usually bought with cash, it’s not surprising that many sales have been to investors.

States sue over school agency layoffs

Deep cuts to federal Education Dept. amount to an illegal shutdown, suit claims.

BY JAWEED KALEEM AND HOWARD BLUME

California on Thursday joined Democratic-led states in suing the Trump administration, seeking to halt massive layoffs at the federal Department of Education, alleging the cuts amount to an illegal shutdown of its work to administer student loans, protect civil rights and help educate students from low-income families and students with disabilities. In the suit, California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta alleged that staff reductions announced this week by Education Secretary Linda McMahon are a “reckless” attempt to follow through on President Trump’s pledge to close the department by making it unable to carry out duties mandated by Congress. Bonta joined attorneys general representing 19 Democratic states and the District of Columbia in the complaint, filed in federal district court in Massachusetts. The Trump administration ordered layoffs that would leave the agency at about half the size it was before the president’s inauguration. McMahon has called the reductions the “first” [See Education, A6]

Owners of Teslas pushing back on Musk

BY CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

In late February, Culver City resident David Andreone posted a photo of his black Model 3 Tesla on Facebook and Instagram and offered it for sale for \$35,000. Though the posts received dozens of comments, no buyers emerged. Andreone, 59, said he loves driving the car but made the decision to sell after the brand’s association with co-founder and Chief Executive Elon Musk became too much to bear. Musk, widely regarded as an eccentric visionary who popularized electric vehicles, has occupied a prominent position in the Trump administration as the leader of the so-called Department of Government Efficiency, or DOGE, since January. Once a champion of climate change activism, Musk now represents President Trump’s agenda, including efforts to downsize the federal government and roll back environmental protections. “I have never in my life bought or leased a car for political reasons,” Andreone said. “Now I feel like I want to” [See Tesla, A8]



RINGO CHIU For The Times

WORKERS remove downed trees and debris on Glencannon Drive in Pico Rivera after a tornado with wind speeds reaching 85 mph touched down in the city.

Light rain gives way to a heavy winter storm in L.A.

Slides in burn areas, major snow in the mountains — and a twister in Pico Rivera.

BY NATHAN SOLIS, HANNAH FRY AND GRACE TOOHEY

After days of light rain, a major storm walloped parts of Southern California on Thursday, bringing fears of mudslides in burn areas, heavy mountain snow, strong winds and a tornado that snapped trees and damaged homes. Bands of heavy precipita-

tion moved through Los Angeles County, prompting reports of some shallow debris flows in burn areas and scattered hail. Intense bursts of rain caused minor street flooding and several closures from southern Santa Barbara County down into Orange County. The Los Angeles Fire Department worked early Thursday to rescue someone stuck on a concrete alcove along the rising Los Angeles River in Boyle Heights. Residents in a Pico Rivera neighborhood were jolted awake when a tornado with wind speeds reaching 85 mph formed around 3:15 a.m. and traveled roughly a

mile, uprooting trees and tossing around outdoor furniture. No injuries were reported. “I heard like a big old bomb. It’s my first tornado,” Edgar Reynoso said as he assessed a collapsed wall in his backyard. “It’s my first time living through it and ... it was pretty scary.” In the mountains around Los Angeles, San Bernardino and Riverside counties, several inches of snow had piled up by Thursday morning, triggering school closures in the area. The San Bernardino Fire Department said it had reports of several power outages. [See Storm, A10]

Republican’s vote puts his seat at risk

Rep. David Valadao’s constituents rely on Medi-Cal and worry benefits will be cut.

BY MELISSA GOMEZ AND FAITH E. PINHO

Rep. David Valadao faced a no-win decision last month: Fall into line behind President Trump and vote for a budget resolution that would almost certainly cut into Medicaid funding, risking his constituents’ wrath; or vote against it, catapulting his party into chaos and setting himself up for a primary opponent possibly backed by Trump. Valadao, a Republican dairy farmer from Hanford, Calif., chose his party. In his speech on the

House floor before the vote, Valadao acknowledged that he’d “heard from countless constituents” advocating for continued support of the program. “I will not support a final reconciliation bill that risks leaving them behind,” he said, adding, “I ask that leadership remains committed to working with my colleagues and I to produce a final product that strengthens critical programs like Medicaid and SNAP and ensures that our constituents are not left behind.” Valadao’s vote came early in a budget process that Republicans say will eventually provide \$2 trillion in savings. Assuming all Democrats vote against a final spending plan — as they did with the budget resolution — House Speaker Mike Johnson (R- [See House, A6]

Federal workers face lengthy appeals
More than 2 million have right to challenge Trump’s firings, but expert notes system’s limits. **NATION, A4**

Difficult stretch for tech stocks
Apple and Google are among the companies bracing for the impact of tariffs. **BUSINESS, A7**

Weather
Rain and drizzle. L.A. Basin: 52/46. **B6**

Roberts loves his Japanese roots
Born in Okinawa, Dodgers manager embraces his heritage. **SPORTS, B10**

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